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SHOW OF FISTS From extreme left, new BJP president Nitin Nabin, PM Modi, ex-party chief J.P. Nadda and Union home minister Amit Shah

on the subject. After over a year of President's Rule and intermittent violence, the party installed Yumnam Khemchand Singh as chief minister in the first week of February, in a bid to bring back an elected government and restore some sense of normalcy. Former chief minister N. Biren Singh had lost all credibility among both the warring communities, the Meitei and the Kuki. The Centre and the BJP are treading carefully here, so as not to destabilise the situation further.

Of the four other states, each presents a different challenge. If in Karnataka, it's about rebuilding a dominant caste coalition, it's about managing internal power equations in Haryana, constructing a political base from the ground up in Punjab, and resolving factional disputes in Delhi.

But such issues are not exclusive to these states, so what exactly is the holdup? Party sources say the BJP leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union home minister Amit Shah are playing a wait-and-watch game for now, as the choice of a state president in the four outliers is closely intertwined with future electoral strategy.

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KARNATAKA CLASH

Karnataka remains the most complicated piece of the BJP's unfinished organisational puzzle. Nearly three years after the party lost the 2023 assembly poll and took a hit in the 2024 general election, the state unit is still mired in an internal power struggle. At the heart of it lies the continuing dominance of octogenarian former chief minister B.S. Yediyurappa (BSY) and his son B.Y. Vijayendra. The party remains broadly divided between the Lingayat old guard aligned with Yediyurappa and a group of leaders who have long opposed his dominance. Vijayendra, the current state president, has the backing of the national leadership, but a reappointment has been fiercely resisted by critics, such as the last BJP CM and now Lok Sabha MP, Basavaraj Bommai, and the party's national general secretary B.L. Santhosh.

For now, BSY, who was recently felicitated for completing 50 years in politics, has made it clear that he has no intention of leaving politics. "God willing, I'll be touring the state for another 5-6 years," the 82-year-old said at a recent event. This picture of enduring vitality isn't exactly filling party rivals with joy.

That said, even those opposing the father-son duo privately concede that the BJP currently lacks an alternative leader capable of consolidating the Lingayat vote—the party's most dependable electoral constituency in the state—while also expanding the broader caste coalition. A top BJP leader explained the strategy for now: "By not formally re-electing Vijayendra as state unit chief, the national leadership has kept the window open and maintained the balance of power in the state. Otherwise, he (BSY) would have already been pitching for Vijayendra to be anointed as the party's chief ministerial candidate in 2028."

Meanwhile, the central leadership has shown little tolerance for factional